Platform-based Cultural Production: Personality, Script, and Myths in China's Grassroots E-commerce Livestream

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Abstract

In recent years, livestream has become an emerging site for China's online shopping industry, through which merchants display the items and demonstrate the usage to attract consumers. However, little is known about the narrative and techniques adopted by grassroots live streamers. Through text analysis of livestream, participant observation and in-depth interviews with grassroots live streamers, this paper investigates into how Chinese grassroots live streamers expand their audience and affect their purchase decisions. They represent themselves as knowledgeable "recommenders" and create coherent narratives to build rapport with audience (Dai, 2019, para. 24). From the perspective of the political economy of communication, this paper further analyzes the affordance of China's e-commerce livestreaming, an emerging technology, and the intrinsic motivation of hosts living on the technology affordance and platform, through three dimensions of livestreaming performance, life picture and Internet myth. With the interwoven identity of e-commerce sellers and landlords, they are busy and anxious, living outside the performance and in the work. Inspired by "Internet mythology ", they are not only producers of the platform economy, but also consumers who are also subject to "network myths". In their vividly individual practice, they feed back the information society on which they live, and write a "grassroots entrepreneurship" story in the real-world they survive and research.

Keywords: livestream, platform economy, digital cultural production, grassroots entrepreneurship, China.

Introduction

With the rapid development of information technology, the information production practice in cyberspace has repeatedly written the picture of society and itself, among which commercial and economic forces have

been playing the most active and the least active leading role.

March 18, 1998, Beijing Friendship Hotel, the century Internet communication technology Co., Ltd. announced to the capital each news unit reporters: Mainland China's first Internet electronic transaction success. Up to now, Internet companies represented by Baidu, Tencent and Alibaba have been continuously transforming and expanding. They not only directly participate in the production of Internet media content, but also touch various information exchange platforms of the Internet through shopping, social networking, education, games and other ways, constantly producing platforms in a new economic form. Market analysis of China's e-commerce industry in 2020: the transaction scale is nearly 35 trillion yuan. The leading role of e-commerce is increasingly prominent, and "e-commerce live streaming" is one of them.

The pandemic has swept the world since 2020. To connect the merchants of "closed" and "no go" consumers, including live on taobao, Trill, Fast, Tencent, Sunning, China electricity giant bought all kinds of Internet platform, offer an olive branch to the merchants, began a rapid opening, credit services and operational guidance, followed a series of supporting measures. (Jarrett, 2014, para. 18). Under the strong support and active advocacy of the platform, merchants in Yiwu International Trade City, the world's largest trade distribution center, have also joined the "e-commerce live streaming" army. In Yiwu commodity market "Cloud Kaishi", 30 million bosses become anchors to attract millions of viewers to watch "not only become a network hot spot, but also become CCTV finance" the first time ", China news network report theme. By the end of April 2020, the number of people engaged in "online celebrity live streaming" in Yiwu exceeded 6,000, among which more than 3,000 were market operators. (China E-commerce Data Center)

In fact, before the birth of the "cloud opening" of the small commodity market, the "live selling goods" activity has already set off a wave in the countryside of Yiwu, in full swing. In Xiazhu Village of Jiangbei, 2.2 kilometers away from Yiwu International Trade City, shops with signs of "Internet celebrity live streaming" can be seen everywhere. It is common to see a young woman carrying five female bags on her mobile phone. In addition, in Qingyanliu Village, 10 kilometers southwest of Xiazhu Village in Jiangbei, "live streaming warehouses", "anchor sales platforms" and "online celebrity training institutions (broker companies)" have also sprung up.

"E-commerce live streaming" has entered the public vision through online, updated the life and consumption patterns of platform economic participants, promoted the development of the real economy through offline, and spawned the main group living in rural areas. As a new form of economic platform and village, e-commerce livestreaming gradually guides the development of the whole market. It is a new form of practitioners and producers created by anchors.

This paper mainly discusses the following core issues: First, how do anchors understand the audience and determine the target audience during livestreaminging; Second, how to attract eyeballs, contact audiences and transform audiences into consumer goods in livestreaming (behavior); Third, offline, as anchors, why do they participate in such activities and what are their self-perceptions based on? Fourth, driven by this motivation, what kind of tasks and requirements do they need to complete, and what kind of living conditions do they generally have?

1. Cultural Production in Platform Economy and Live-streaming E-commerce

Looking back on the many researches on platform economy, it can be roughly sorted into three theoretical threads: first, taking platform as a form of development of media industry, reflecting and predicting the development of industry from a macro perspective, and deeply discussing the political and economic centrality and social embeddedness behind it; Second, cultural producers focusing on the platform economy, including the nature of their careers on the platform (Internet celebrities, merchants, digital workers) and their social identities outside the Internet; Third, on the basis of grasping the macro framework of platform economy and the main identity of cultural producers, the "commercialization" nature, "participatory" cultural motivation and transformative forms of cultural production of platform economy are interpreted in a variety of ways.

This paper takes Kuaishou, a video sharing platform, as a specific perspective to study the platformization of Chinese cultural production. Kuaishou is an algorithm-based video sharing platform for second - and third-tier cities and rural areas. It has created an "incredible" creative class in contemporary China. Kuaishou's platform business is in line with the country's socio-economic "Internet Plus" and "mass entrepreneurship and innovation" agenda, as well as the country's demand for cultural censorship and social stability. Still, Kuaishou has given the diverse, often marginalized Chinese who live outside the country the

chance to become "unlikely" creative workers in the country's urban centers, who have become self-employed, digital creative worker entrepreneurs. For these "grassroots individuals," creativity, life and personality are constantly being mobilized and counted. According to the operation of the platform. This grassroots entrepreneurship, combined with institutional regulation that goes hand in hand with Internet censorship, has helped transform China's economy and stabilize its society, producing a digital culture of contingency and negotiation.

1.1 Digital Labor and the Chinese Platform Cultural Economy

As a global phenomenon, the platform economy has been widely criticized for the type of labor it involves. For example, Van points out that in the platform economy, contract labor has been replaced by "platform labor" that adopts a "more rigorous and zero-liability peer-to-peer model that uses software to optimize labor for flexibility, scalability, operability, and fragmentation. (Van, 2017, para.203) " In this sense, workers are treated as supplements or subcontractors of the platform company, rather than employees, and therefore do not provide labor protection. Critical political economists have also attacked content-based platforms for promoting the exploitation of free, creative labor by deliberately inviting users to become "production consumers".

Although these arguments provide valuable insights into new labor conditions in the global platform economy, they often ignore the positive agency or individual practices of digital/platform creators. The "multi-party market" of platform enterprises indicates that there are more complex relationships between different actors in the operation of platformization, and the networked model of cultural production shows that the "cost of production and consumption of goods and services" affects other complements of the platform, such as content producers and advertisers, and vice versa. (Ritzer, 2010, para.14). The business relationship between platform companies and compliers is not only exploitative, but also collaborative and symbiotic, so the long-term financial success of a digital platform is not simply based on the exploitation of platform labor, but rather depends on commercial partnerships between platform companies, content producers, and other complementors. In the case of Kuaishou, we will show in the following sections that by actively exploiting the digital systems provided by the platform, "grassroots" content producers have been able to develop a kind of digital creative entrepreneurship.

1.2 Walking Through Kuaishou: Algorithmic and Digital Governance

Founded in 2012, Kuaishou is an algorithm-based video and live streaming platform that allows registered users to create and publish various short videos online. These video shows from cooking, fitness, skills training, make up to all kinds of activities of the movie, tens of millions of Internet users are very diverse, the content of the calculated by the algorithm of fast worker recommendation system and push to the target audience, as Gillespie (2014) suggests, this algorithm system replaced the traditional edit choose in the content and distribution , offers a seemingly more "objective" model based on artificial intelligence (AI) calculations of user data rather than the "subjective" preferences of editors. (Sun, 2010, para.58). The most important distinguishing feature of Kuaishou is that most of its users are young Chinese who have come to the countryside or third - and fourth-tier cities for education. As we will show, Kuaishou makes this group an "unlikely creative class", actively expressing their indigenous creativity through self-study skills, which is also one of the intrinsic conditions for survival under the Internet. In addition, they use Kuaishou's digital systems to monetize their creative production through advertising and e-commerce. At first glance, Kuaishou's platform content business and "unlikely creative class" seem to fit well with the country's aspirations for a "mass sword industry".

Using algorithmic logic, Kuaishou has created a seemingly decentralized, democratic system of content production and selection. In principle, everyone is treated equally by algorithmic machines, whether they are movie stars or migrant workers. The key to content production is to generate as much online traffic as possible through creative content. Kuaishou describes itself with slogans such as "Interesting stuff" and "Record the world, record you," according to its online archive and its updates on Apple's App Store. On its web page, three sentences appear under this new slogan: Discover a real and interesting world, be true to yourself without feeling lonely, Same town in the same mood.

These lines evoke concepts of the world, self, and locality, so that the content provided is rooted in the everyday reality of China. Images shared on the web and in app stores further reinforce this sense of the everyday: ordinary young Chinese are captured in everyday situations, traveling, at home, with pets or babies, etc. Keywords such as "real", "self", "interesting" and "the same", together with the photos, embody Kuaishou's vision: to invite "grassroots individuals" to discover and share interesting moments from the

"real" daily lives of themselves and others. Kuaishou promises to provide an online community that is fun, authentic, personal but not lonely, absorbing the creativity of users into the platform economy. (Lin & Jeroen, 2019)

By exploiting the various digital affordances and character setting, “grassroots” content producers have, on the one hand, become self-employed creative entrepreneurs for whom creativity, life, and individuality are constantly calculated according to the accounting of costs and profits. On the other hand, in the everyday production and management of affect through the digital affordances provided by Kuaishou, these creative individuals also become aspirational creative workers (Duffy, 2016, p. 441) motivated by the platform’s “promise of social and economic capital; yet the reward system for these aspirants is highly uneven.” A data-driven economy becomes the common model that drives all the parts becoming complementors of the platform.

1.3 Mythologies of the Internet

The past few years have seen the emergence of a new paradigm of professional success - e-commerce live streaming. With the wide application of the concept of "Internet plus live streaming", the rapid development of e-commerce platforms, online live streaming has changed the traditional concept of sales. Many businesses with traditional sales models have gradually embarked on the road of e-commerce innovation.

It is hard to imagine that live streaming e-commerce can still maintain its fabulous growth rate on the huge base of e-commerce industry scale exceeding 10 trillion yuan. On August 20, Alibaba's new quarterly financial disclosure data showed that the transaction guided by Taobao live has been 8 consecutive quarters of year-on-year growth of more than 100%. And that looks far from the end of the growth. Merchant live streaming, which has risen rapidly this year, is expected to be the next flashpoint. In the transaction brought by Taobao livestreaming, the proportion of merchant livestreaming is more than 60%, creating the myth of the Internet.

2.Research Questions

In the framework of political economy of communication, platform economy studies comprehensively forecast platform and social development, emphasizing the centrality and embeddedness of economy, politics and technology. From the perspective of sociology and political economy, the identities of each subject within the platform are differentiated, with special attention paid to "regulation", "platform rent", "digital labor" and other issues, emphasizing the interdependence and mutual restriction of each subject within the platform. From the perspective of cultural studies, the cultural content of the platform is deconstructed and regarded as "elite culture", "grassroots culture" and "consumer culture" in a broad sense. As a platform for cultural production and internal activities, e-commerce activities can provide new concrete cases than any other type of theoretical path, but the researchers decided to start from the phenomenon of e-commerce. On the one hand, the author will explore the "cultural commodity" that advocates consumerism and causes "materialism" -- live performance, and then summarize the "prospect" performance paradigm of this platform.

On the other hand, the author will show the "producers and consumers" of the digital economy, the representatives of "local culture", the new elite of small-town youth, and their broad "background" and the status of anchors. The research questions are divided into the following two parts:

The first is online, how do the host understand the audience, determine the target audience, attract eyeballs in the livestreaming (performance), acquire the audience, and convert the audience into consumer goods? Second, offline, as anchors, why do they participate in such activities? Based on what self-perception? What kind of tasks and requirements do they have to fulfill, and what kind of life do they have in general, driven by this motivation?

Prospect -- Through online viewing, the author tries to describe the appearance of the cultural content produced by these anchors, especially the specific expression and content of the livestreaming by anchors. The following questions are important for this study. How do they get eyeballs, get an audience, and turn that audience into consumers? What are the necessary links and processes involved in these shows (such as trade shows and talent shows)? (Chang, 2019, para. 5) How is this different from traditional mall guides and street vendors? How does the host personally understand the identity relationship between himself and the target audience, "pro" and "Lao tie", performer and audience, business and customer? How exactly do

they prepare (such as scripting, device preparation, and setup)? How can they take advantage of the platform's features (live streaming, short videos, merchandise links, etc.) and make it an opportunity for them? What practical challenges do they face (platform regulation, technical barriers)?

Background -- Through offline observation and interview, the personal motivation of anchors is transmitted as listeners, and the lifestyle and life pictures of anchors are recorded as participants. How were the presenters inspired to come here for the live event and form a group with each other? What kind of identity do they have and what kind of culture do they constitute? Under the overlapping and interweaving of the identities of anchors and merchants, what is the specific role of anchors and to what extent do they meet the job requirements? What is the general state of life?

3.Data Collection

This research mainly adopts a combination of online text analysis and offline field investigation (participatory observation and in-depth interview). In terms of text analysis, the live videos of e-commerce anchors (including but not limited to field research objects) are transcribed, and their "live streaming with goods" behaviors such as commodity display and talent show are analyzed. In terms of field investigation, the author takes "Qingyanliu" and "Xiazhu" e-commerce villages in Yiwu as empirical research sites (field investigation), seeks anchors engaged in "live streaming selling goods" in both places as research objects, and analyzes their offline life pictures by means of participatory observation and in-depth interview.

Following the purposive sampling principle, this study tried to find as rich and comprehensive representative interview subjects as possible in the two e-commerce villages according to anchors' gender, working hours, career experience, platform selection, number of fans and other indicators, and a total of 8 interviewees were recorded. The basic data of the respondents in this study are summarized as follows:

Table 1. Basic data table of interviewees

No.	Gender	Salary (Month)	The original professional	Fans

F1	F	43	Physical store owner	268,800
F2	F	7	Physical store owner	186,000
F3	F	3	WeChat electrical contractor	822
F4	F	2	Factory odd jobs	585
M1	M	8	Booth	951,000
M2	M	4	Physical store owner	171,000
M3	M	2	Taobao mall	18,809

Main source: China E-commerce Data Center

Among the 8 interviewees, 4 were male (50%) and 4 were female (50%). They work over a number of time periods and fall roughly into three categories: "newbies" who make less than three months a month, "developers" who make more than three months but less than six months, and "leaders" who make more than six months. (Chen, 2019, para. 51). (Zhang, 2019, para. 351) Their work experience is also varied. Their final jobs include brick-and-mortar businesses, e-commerce, factory odd jobs, street vendors and other businesses. In terms of platform selection, some respondents chose original e-commerce platforms (such as Taobao and Pinduoduo), while some respondents chose original short video social platforms (such as Kuaishou and Douyin). On major livestream platforms, the number of their fans varies greatly, ranging from three digits (hundreds) to nearly eight digits (millions), which usually determines their commercial value, which is roughly positively correlated with the income of anchors.

1. Different platforms limit the visibility they can use, and there are slight differences in the specific interaction methods, but the basic functions (live streaming, providing links to buy goods) are the same, and the performance paradigm is similar.

2. Revenue is not only related to the quantity of goods sold and the sales volume, but also related to the profit margin of different categories, which is difficult to calculate. The author tried to find out in the

interview, but most of the anchors were reluctant to reveal their actual income.

3. A host may use multiple accounts on different platforms to broadcast live at the same time, and the number of fans is dynamically changing, so April 26, 2020 is chosen for this paper. For example, M1 uses multiple accounts of Douyin and Kuaishou at the same time, and selects the fan number of Kuaishou account with the largest number of fans (K788688) for statistics. In addition, when the number of fans exceeds ten thousand, the platform will take "ten thousand" as the measurement unit and only keep two decimal places, so the number of fans of anchors with more than ten thousand fans can only be accurate to one thousand.

During the fieldwork period (early March to mid-April 2020), the authors conducted participatory observation for each subject for 4-5 weeks, during which three in-depth interviews were conducted. Due to the limited number of objects, the specific observation and interview content will be semi-structured designed on the basis of online observation, and the data will be sorted through open source coding. In terms of observation, the author participated in at least three times of each anchor live events (interview early, middle and late), and live with the host before preparation (such as the choice of products, product purchase, short live site layout, product preview video shooting, etc.), as well as live after delivery and after-sale work (e.g., return). Based on some of the information collected, the interviews were refined (see Appendix).

4. Live performance, releasing charm and stimulating material desire

Live streaming is not a new concept. Live streaming is also evolving from game broadcasting, pan-entertainment broadcasting to e-commerce live-streaming showing the development trend of "everything can be broadcast" (such as online consultation, online education, etc.). Different from the previous live streaming of games and singing and dancing, anchors engaged in e-commerce live streaming often appear on the screen as sellers. In this sense, anchors are similar to shopping guides in shopping malls, but they transform offline shopping guides online through livestreaming, turning the original one-to-one explanation into one-to-many interactive explanation on the platform. (Xing, 2017, para. 91). In this new real-time interactive livestreaming and sales form with multiple explanations, anchors must set up "human devices"

to release their charm, introduce products in specific "scenes" and stimulate consumers' desire to buy them through words like "it's so beautiful, my mom" and "it's a good deal, buy him buy him".

4.1 character setting：Recommender and Seller

In the past, people used online shopping platforms to buy something they "needed" in real life at a relatively "low" price. However, nowadays, people do not refuse to be "planted grass" by anchors, and even don't care what anchors sell. Instead, they have the desire to buy based on their trust in anchors. In this case, they usually do Content monetization by means of virtual gift monetization (Peng Ao, 2016, p. 40-44); In addition, the number of fans, the number of likes and the number of viewers in the online broadcast room can be exchanged with advertisers as the "audience commodity" -- "10 fans for one yuan" (interviewee M2). The "retail business review" of We-media and the digital intelligent transformation mode of the retail industry described in the "Popularity" of live e-commerce are worthy of our thinking and learning.

Take Viya's studio for example, its ability to do business is a full range of categories, not only clothing, but also beauty, snacks, home appliances, daily necessities, as well as tickets, books, and maybe even selling houses through live streaming in the future. At present, Taobao Live has sold cars and houses, covering catering, tourism, film and television, book publishing and other industries (Retail Business Review, 2020).

In the article, the "enabling" effect of platform anchors on merchants and commodities is roughly consistent with the identity of anchors in Yiwu e-commerce village. Relying on the advantages of complete categories (daily necessities, ornaments, shoes and hats, toys, etc.), strong fashion design consciousness and high rate of new products in Yiwu market, these anchors do not have specific sales categories and audiences. In general, anyone watching the livestream can leave a message on the platform asking them to help them buy what they need. As a result, these anchors become "referees" and "pickers" for the audience (see Figure 1).

Figure 1. Self-introduction of the "mining"



Rely on real-time interactive platform to broadcast function, these anchors are holding a mobile phone, street, small commodity market in yiwu inventory on the rampage, swept around, every now and then stopped in diligently "since said the words," on a cell phone in a slightly noisy intruder identity "show you (the audience) yiwu", let the audience to choose goods, and the whole process of business negotiation.

"Everybody OLD IRON (老铁), I COME HERE TODAY IS TO GO TO THE MARKET FOR EVERYBODY, HAVE WANT TO buy the commodity TO say quickly, quickly command me. I'm ready to break my leg." (M4)”

"Babies(宝宝), if you want [this product], please report your size and color on the screen and let's make a count. Many people, we can buy a group and the boss about the price. Every baby who comes to this studio today is equivalent to coming to Yiwu. We want to get cheap and good goods." (Interviewee F1)

As "mining"(“采带员”), the host often in live with "we (the host) to the audience" combined "to bargain with the boss '" this way to let the audience realized that the host belongs to a" community of interests "with him, and with" broken "(to the audience) or" (audience) use such words to build a subordinate to the identity of the audience, So as to enhance the intimacy between the two and establish a trust relationship.

In fact, the bargaining process of many anchors is not impromptu livestreaming, but the result of rehearsal. In order to ensure profit, they have set a minimum selling price and share ratio with some merchants before the broadcast. In this "recommendation" mode, F1, a interviewee with three years of industry experience, has achieved long-term cooperation with brands such as Langsa（浪莎）, Mona（梦娜）、and Knock Sugar Gang（敲糖帮）.

Figure 2. The self-introduction of the "merchant"



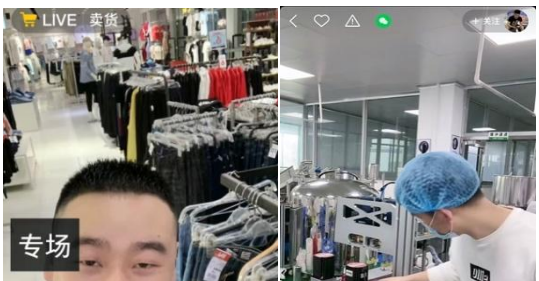
In fact, these "bargain" "merchants", because they have a primary source of goods, more cost-effective goods, become another widespread "people set" in the e-commerce village of Yiwu. (Ran, 2018, para. 87). They regard themselves as "merchants" (see Figure 2 on the left) or "source manufacturers" (see Figure 2 on the right) that understand the market conditions at the first time, and promote their competitiveness with propaganda words such as "manufacturers direct sales, quantity is superior".

Whether they are "recommender" or "merchant", anchors exchange information with consumers, improve quality and meet demands during live streaming interaction, expanding Yiwu's traditional offline market to online platforms, forming a virtuous cycle of promotion, sales, interaction and optimization.

4.2 Scene: factory, market

According to the researcher of "e-commerce livestreaming", "realistic shopping scenes... A "life-like" scene "(Shen Guoliang, 2020, p. 95), which echoes the" real situation "in the foreground emphasized by Goffman (1989). No matter "real situation" or "life scene", for anchors, it is their due meaning of livestreaminging. Compared with the lighting, shelves and even wallpaper, wallpaper are carefully designed big anchors, these "merchants" and "recommenders" are adapted to local conditions, often based on their own warehouses, factories, Yiwu commodity markets, "factory direct sales" and "shopping" and other activities.

Figure 3. Anchors take viewers around commodity markets (left) and their own factories (right)



"Good goods promoters" represented by interviewee F1 regard the commodity market in Yiwu as their "blue sea". They are in the well-known "Yiwu Small Commodity Market", with the way of "taking you shopping", to show the audience in front of the camera a variety of commodities in the market. From tiaras and silver stores in Zone 1, hardware in Zone 2, office supplies in Zone 3, clothes in Zone 4 to toys in Zone 5 (see Figure 3 left), the livestream connects online audiences with offline stores, leading the audience to enter the "small commodity city, shopper's paradise".

"Merchants" are often able to get through all links of commodity production and circulation. M3, the representative respondent, has been engaged in Taobao e-commerce industry since college, and has her own lipstick factory at the age of 25. His lens focuses on the production and assembly lines of cosmetics (see chart 3), demonstrating his prowess as a businessman. However, there are also some "referees" who pretend to be factory owners who will enter a certain boss's factory and introduce "their factory" to the audience in front of the camera (interviewee M4).

4.3 Script: Merchandise, theme

This "scenography" has been criticized by some scholars engaged in cultural studies as "the body aesthetics of contemporary China that reduces the ideological demands of fans to the body of the main broadcast" in online videos (Li Yiyang, 2019, p. 58; Chen Yuangui, 2019, pp. 99-102); For the anchors, the practice has no aesthetic meaning, but is simply a practice of selling physical goods on a digital currency platform. Colloquially, "If you put up a link and it says' for sale 'on the cover, what is that person doing

here if they don't buy anythi

Fi  m

With the theme of "shopping/selling goods" marked on the cover (see "selling goods" in the upper left corner of Figure 4), anchors usually design livestreaming scripts from two aspects: preparation of single items and the whole process. (Zhang, 2012, para. 68).

Single product: refine selling points

A single product, as the name suggests, is a single product/commodity. The single product script usually includes the selling point of the product, the brand, the discount way. Among them, the introduction of selling points is the most important and often causes anchors the most headaches. They must capture the psychology of the audience, understand "what their customers want and care about" (respondent M3), and then demonstrate the selling point of the product in words or actions.

Language, cosmetics, clothing, Musical Instruments and other goods color, shape, sound image has gone through stereo video, visually displayed to the user, the host must also is one of the best speeches and sensory taste, the smell of food and other commodities also describe to the audience, at the same time also need to point out some cannot pass on the personal feelings, but the goods characteristics of audience attraction, for example, whether (arts and crafts) It's handmade, it's natural, and so on. (Gregg, 2020, para. 298). In order to highlight the selling point of the product, the host also needs to understand one or two

similar competing products, as well as the attributes and characteristics of competing products, analyze the advantages of the product, and facilitate the introduction.

In terms of actions, anchors also need to use their brains and hands to prove the marketability of products with the help of some props in live videos. For example, to indicate that a sock product is "unscratchable," the host (interviewee F1) could place a pineapple in the sock and shake it back and forth. For example, in order to prove that a pair of sunglasses has a good UV protection effect, the host (interviewee M2) would place the sunglasses on a piece of pig skin and bake them for five minutes with an UV lamp. Some streamers use cutting steel balls to explain that razors have enough horsepower and good performance, and they use gas canisters to demonstrate the strength of the tape (see Figure 5). In short, "all written descriptions pale in the face of [these] visual video presentations" (respondent F3).

Figure 5. Use props to show selling points



Theme: Tandem flow

Experienced "good stuff promoters" (Respondent F1) will also stress that a livestreaming of more than three hours requires 10 to 20 products. Therefore, after preparing the presentation script of a single product, the anchor needs to write the script of the whole livestreaming. During the livestreaming, "we have to make

a plan and arrangement for our livestreaming schedule" (interviewee F1).

As an analogy, when you walk into a mall, the shopping guide will habitually say that this jacket will look better with this pair of pants and shoes. E-commerce live streaming is not a simple sales logic of a single product, there is a relationship between products. The choice of topics is very flexible. Only by choosing the theme well and combining it deeply, can the reader have more interest to read on. (Gregg, 2020, para. 286).

Among all kinds of "topics" (themes) such as festivals, seasons and categories, "promotion festivals" constructed by anchors are the most common, such as "Kuaishou E-commerce Festival Carnival", "Spring Good things Sharing", "Goddess Festival Promotion" and "Fan Fan Carnival" (see Figure 6 for background). Just like the "Double 11 shopping Festival" and the TV evening on the same day, which constructs the "commodity culture", these "shopping festivals" just give some meaning to the goods and the purchase behavior (such as the "Goddess festival" describes the goods as "goddess" necessities) in order to promote consumption. (Gray, 2003, para. 503).

Secondly, the host will also link the livestreaming with the audience's certain realistic needs as the theme. On the topic of "How to wear it in early spring", interviewee F1 systematically introduced the previously scattered and independent commodities such as plaid shirts and long skirts, which made the audience interested in these grouped commodities.

At the very least, in the context of Yiwu's unique market, the host will also use the local characteristics of Yiwu as live topics such as "Take you around the International Trade City", "Yiwu specialty recommendation", "Yiwu Market brand tail" (see the lower left corner of Figure 6) to carry out product sales.

Figure 6. "Fan Fan Carnival" theme livestreaming



Under these themes that can connect the selling points of commodities, a complete livestreaming can be divided into five parts: opening interaction, commodity explanation, raffle, trade guidance and warm-up for the next livestreaming.

First, the anchor greets fans and briefly introduces the main items, especially the best-selling ones. To accommodate new users entering the studio, editors reintroduce the product every once in a while. Second is the single product explanation mentioned above, namely product explanation. Generally speaking, in order to ensure that customers stay for a long time, you can put the hot products in the back, and at the same time in different products between the hot products. Third, in order to promote the sales of goods, anchors will draw prizes through coupons (mainly on Taobao platforms) or red envelopes (mainly on Kuaishou and Douyin platforms) to benefit customers (see Figure 7 "red envelopes"). In the lucky draw, M4, the respondent, once gave 3,000 yuan in red envelopes to the live audience, but the net profit of a single livestreaming did not exceed 3,000 yuan. His verdict: "Don't go live, the lottery is over. You have to do this multiple times to retain users. You can see celebrities handing out 'million red envelopes' three times during the Spring Festival."(Wang, 2017, para. 51).

Figure 7. Anchors encourage customers to "grab red envelopes" in the broadcast room



In addition, after the product introduction and preferential distribution are completed, the host will

provide the product link to the customer in the livestreaming room and guide the customer to click the link to buy. Finally, after the livestreaming ends, the host will preview the next livestreaming in advance, explaining its general content and scheduled time, so as to attract more users to the studio to watch the livestreaming. "A mature live stream should be cyclical, and retaining users is key. Only by getting users into the habit can you increase the visibility of your studio." (Candidate, F1)

4.4 Skills: interaction, speech, acting

Based on selling goods of the script, the host often need to master the skills necessary to lose his own studio, and through specific interaction, text, or TV shows to attract viewers, so that they have to participate in, so as to maintain the host and their relationship, not only let them stay in a television, convert them into fan for a long time. (Zhou, 2005, para. 118).

In terms of sales speech skills, anchors will use different speech skills in different stages of script setting according to different platforms. Take the Taobao platform where F1 is located as an example: when guiding users to place an order, it will say "the anchor has put the product on the link, and the baby you like can click the link below to buy it quickly"; In order to increase the heat, the host will often say "there is a baby in ah, you say a word, I am not on a card, can’t see you speak, online baby button 1" or "the baby likes the anchor or feel good goods, send a love to the anchor", in order to stimulate the enthusiasm of audience participation; In an emergency, the anchor would say, "Babies, please don't go away. After the host changes the flow, the live stream will not be stuck. Don't go away. When preparing to end the livestreaming, the host will first say "speak in advance × minutes, × minutes later livestreaming" to rehearse. Before the end of the show, the host will say good wishes such as "Thank you so much for your support and wish your health and happiness" to maintain the relationship with the audience. In addition, there are tricks to turn viewers into fans, such as "babies who like anchors and want to continue learning about costume matching/delicious/beautiful makeup (the main category of anchors), can follow anchors." On Kuaishou platform, the scope of application and specific application situation are similar, but the audience name will be changed from "Bao Bao" to "Lao Tie", which is the popular "Lao Tie" on Kuaishou platform.

Figure 8. Carpet rhymes used by anchors to attract customers



In terms of interaction, anchors can selectively use the software functions provided by the platform (Afford). In order to attract and retain audiences, many anchors will perform in talent shows (respondents F3 and M4) even if they are not good at dancing or singing. (Mears, 2011, para. 24). Others use "non-talent talent" to attract customers, such as "rhymes" used to attract popularity when setting up stalls.

Go forward, stand forward, there is no atomic bomb in front, hold on to come and have a look, stand too far to see. Net said, look, look at the back of the head, head is full of hair, or didn't look at anything, come and take a look, is better than new products just come, on China central television (CCTV), went to the central countries report, the national people's all know that if you don't know, is certainly not signal a TV at home, approached guy talk from the beginning to the end.

Respondents with five years of street stall experience M1, regard this as their own "secret book", not only used to call the studio audience, but also complete "rhyming" edited into a volume, at 88 yuan per volume of the price of sales to the audience who want to engage in street sales work.

Figure 9. Anchors sell their rhymes in the broadcast room



5.Backstage: Life behind the scenes, chasing dreams and never ending

Beyond the "front desk" of live performances, the life of an anchor has a broader context. The background here not only includes the personal life picture of anchors, but also includes the social background that influences them to embark on the road of "anchors". (Hochschild, 1983, para. 24).

5.1 Picture of life: in addition to performance, in work

When scholars as "digital labor" to mark the host's workers, they tend to focus on the work in the game, in the host's song and dance performance, such as their "virtual gift reward" to complete the "cash" or the number of fans, the number of likes, the number of network viewers, as a "commodity" audience and advertisers. However, anchors engaged in e-commerce live streaming not only rely on live camera activities to promote commodities, but also need to be responsible for offline physical exchange of commodities and services, and deal with the selection, distribution, return and exchange of commodities. The status of anchors makes them have to meet all kinds of new requirements and constantly improve themselves to meet the requirements of being on camera. In the process of constantly learning from the outside world and sharpening themselves, in the interweaving of the Internet and the Internet of things, it is difficult for their life picture to be separated from their work. They live outside of acting, but they also exist at work.

Work: busy sellers without rest

Both inside and outside the broadcast, the working hours and working hours of anchors are often unimaginable to ordinary people.

On the Internet, respondents often choose to broadcast F1 live late at night in order not to compete with well-known anchors for fans. She broadcast for more than 10 hours from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m. the next day with samples from suppliers. Offline, anchors also participate in the early selection, homework, collocation,

planning, etc., just a piece of clothing, it needs to match a variety of dressing methods. In addition to designing the content and form of livestreaminging, anchors also need to confirm the logistics of livestreaminging in the early stage, such as network speed, livestreaminging hardware and software.

Figure 10. Livestreaming equipment of anchors





Had some experience of the author in the process of observation, the host will reconfirm before a live microphone, camera equipment, they generally need to prepare at least one mobile phone, a mobile phone is used in the process of live, a mobile phone is used in a timely manner in the process of watching live interactive, multiple platforms host more will be prepared for a phone. (see figure 10)

However, when the village of electricity "well-known host" like Li Jiaqi when peace came to power, the eu's "anchor head" has been broadcast live or selected products, planning and design of the script (such as testing equipment, sets) on the previous work, a few small anchor also need a or take one or two partners is responsible for the delivery and return.

Figure 11. Storage environment shown in livestreaming by anchors





M2 and his wife usually broadcast at midnight and then packed up thousands of items from the warehouse and shipped them in four hours (see Figure 11). M1 used to count the order number of each channel in the afternoon, squatting on the ground to clear the goods of 10,000 yuan; Respondents F3 and M4 often take the samples used in the livestreaming, run around the market to find buyers according to the demand, and then go back to compare one by one and quickly pack. They also have to deal with buyers returning or exchanging goods for the wrong size or impulse purchase after they are shipped. "My current rate of return and conversion is about 20%" (respondent M2), but "after all, he buys something from you, the money goes into your pocket, and you are responsible for it and the person who buys it, aren't you? (Candidate M4)

In such a long, multi-tasking job, anchors can be hoarse from asking questions (interviewee F1) for an entire year.

"I don't know if it's because I don't drink water or go to the toilet when I'm on the show, or because I'm constantly trying on clothes and doing a lot of exercise, but I've lost a lot of weight since being on the show." (Applicant F1)

Need for performance: Anxious, nonstop anchors

In the process of preliminary preparation, mid-stage livestreaming and post-sale work, these self-regarded "struggling" anchors (interviewees F4 and M4) have almost no spare time for themselves. Even if they have spare time, they tend to spend it on developing their livestreaminging and hosting careers.

In order to increase the number of viewers and fans in their livestreaming room, F2 specially signed up for the training of Xiayai Network Celebrity Livestreaming Organization (company legal person: Zhejiang

Shanglong Network Technology Co., LTD.) in Xiazhu Village, Jiangbei. Through training, she began to understand how to improve her "physical and mental charisma" to attract people:

"Not everyone is beautiful, and not everyone can start the Victoria's Secret runway with a perfect body, but you have to treat every live show like a performance and rely on your physical and inner charm to attract the audience. If you don't have a clue, try to dress like the stars or see how other anchors dress."

At present, the respondents are still engaged in the sales of lipstick, lip glaze and other cosmetics, and the daily sales of M3 are basically stable at about 2000 orders. He often worried that his current sales would decline, so he made regular daily trips to the studios of each platform and studied everywhere:

"I often look at studios of all kinds and look first at what they're wearing. Anchors for food and furniture, for example, are simply dressed to feel like home. Anchors of digital products are more otaku; Financial anchors tend to wear suits and ties; Then see how they introduce the product, like what Li Jiaki said 'buy it buy him' and other catchphrases; Then we'll see how he uses the various functions. Recently, I wanted to buy a live streaming host and give it a try. (Lin, 2013, para. 286). I can switch scenes, not only to the model's face, but also to my warehouse or factory assembly line."

For some anchors, it's through interaction with the audience in the studio or feedback from friends that they find their shortcomings and then try to correct them. Everyone has all kinds of problems. Some struggle with mobile devices, trying to learn how to list product links and configure a stable network (Respondent M4), while others are constrained by dialects (Respondent F4), struggling to improve their Mandarin and trying to mimic the anchor they crave.

In the hearts of many platform anchors, live streaming is an opportunity of The Times and a "gold rush". However, when they engage in this "consumer culture" and try to cause what cultural critics see as the new human disease "Affluenza," they become a psychologically overburdened and anxious bunch. They hold the mentality that "pigs can fly when standing in the wind", seize the opportunity, and work nervously and busily. At the same time, they understand that "the dividend will disappear and the wind will turn", constantly chasing industry benchmarks and seeking personal development direction in anxiety. (Ao, 2016, para.41).

5.2 Myth inspiration: "Internet celebrities", grassroots entrepreneurs, gold rush outlet

For never-ending anchors/sellers, their determination comes from their dreams at the individual level as well as joint efforts at the social level. It is the product of the spreading/ubiquitous appeal of popular terms such as "Internet celebrity", "grassroots entrepreneur" and "gold rush" under the guidance of technical support, policy guarantee and public opinion.

"Wanghong" (Internet celebrities)

As an identity tag, "Internet celebrity" has not only been widely used in the research of platform culture producers, but also become a sign and symbol offline. It has become the slogan of Xiazhu Village in Jiangbei -- "The first village of Internet celebrity livestreaminging" (see Figure 12).

Figure 12. The PUBLICITY board OF "Jiangbei XiaZHU Village"



attract business -- "Internet celebrity food", "Internet celebrity commodity". The term "Internet celebrity" is not only widely used in the field, but also respected among the interviewed anchors.

"To be a host, you have to have more than 100,000 followers. Otherwise, you can't even be a (professional) host. You can only try." F1 interviewees only sleep 5-6 hours a day and rest 3-4 days a month. In more than 3 years, the total number of fans has reached 266,800, and the annual sales volume of the broadcast room is close to 20 million.

"Grassroots Entrepreneurs"

For e-commerce village anchors, they have yet to reach 100,000 followers, at least initially. They are often inspired by "influencers" such as interviewee F1. After the local COVID-19 quarantine was lifted, they came to Yiwu and the e-commerce village from the surrounding provinces (respondents M3) or cities (respondents F2 and F4) with expectations. Here they are strangers who have not yet established

themselves. M4, a respondent from Shenyang, Liaoning Province, admitted:

"I was a chef for more than 20 years, but I fell in love with Kuaishou early on. When I got drunk and threw the big rocket on the anchor. I see these profitable anchors are quite good at telling jokes, you see that Kuaishou that the whole billion 'Simba', and Yiwu this' Anroxi ', I think I can see. So I wondered if I could switch careers and cross over to do it."

For these "anchors" who come to Yiwu alone, they often pretend to be "grassroots entrepreneurs". The label "grassroots" can also be seen in their past work experience. Some of them work in factories in packaging and assembly (Interviewee F4), some are cooks (Interviewee M4) and some are street vendors (interviewee M1 and F3).

Figure 13. Screenshot of short video in Kuaishou platform



Inspired by "A Billion People Dream Dragon Brother" with 2.215 million followers and "Guan Yu Brother" with 1.76 million followers, after hearing the myth that "some people wear shorts and flip flops when they go to the village, and upgrade their electric tricycles to BMW, Audi and Bentley in two years" and "some people make 'super models' that can net more than 7 million yuan a day", These "grassroots" people from all over the world who do not want to "work" have come to the e-commerce village where more than 2,000 Internet celebrities are active and more than 5,000 practitioners related to video live streaming have gathered to make every effort to realize their "wealth dream" (see Figure 12) and create a

unique "e-commerce live streaming" culture.

They are quick in their hands and enjoy "grassroots" entertainment and activities like "Shouting" and "PK". During the outbreak of COVID-19 in 2020, they searched for their own development opportunities through the Internet and found such a "paradise" of grassroots entrepreneurs (see Figure 13), so as to complete the jump in class.

"Gold Rush"

The realization of individual self-development must be built on the basis of social class mobility, which needs the guidance of the state as a political power and the support and encouragement as a commercial power platform.

National Policy

As a new form of platform economy, "e-commerce live streaming" is closely related to "Internet Plus" and "mass entrepreneurship and innovation" policies (The State Council, 2015A). "Internet Plus" complements the "mass entrepreneurship" strategy, in which "a booming digital economy provides jobs for individuals at the grassroots level to become entrepreneurs," thereby increasing class mobility. Premier Li Keqiang said:

"Internet +" is not only to add a new kinetic energy, and it is one of the biggest share of economic platform, for the masses entrepreneurship, innovation has provided a broad stage, driving the profound changes in the economic and social life, make scientific and technological elite, entrepreneurs, have more opportunities to show, more let hundreds of millions of grassroots can play ingenuity, show their unique value. (Li Keqiang, People's Daily online, Beijing, March 20, 2018 -- Chinese Premier Li Keqiang meets and answers questions from Chinese and foreign journalists covering the first session of the 13th National People's Congress in the Golden Hall on the third floor of the Great Hall of the People.)

Against the background of the national strategies of "Internet Plus" and "mass entrepreneurship", 2019 has become the "first year of e-commerce live streaming". On the one hand, the anchors on the e-commerce platform are soaring with their goods. Taobao Live guided nearly 20 billion yuan of transactions on the

"Double 11" day, with more than 10 billion yuan in livestreaming rooms and more than 100 million yuan in livestreaming rooms. The number of self-broadcast companies and the number of broadcast events has doubled year-on-year. On the other hand, short video social platforms have become popular online and become e-commerce companies. Douyin pioneered the "618 Year of Good Deeds and Great Rewards", which encourages Internet celebrities to recommend products to users through short videos and live streaming. The top 30 experts in commodity transport capacity helped the total amount of goods to exceed 400 million yuan. Five months later, Kuaishou held the "116 E-commerce Shopping Festival", with the host Simba selling 400 million yuan in a single day. In 2020, the development of "e-commerce live streaming" will be greatly boosted by the outbreak of "novel coronavirus".

During the quarantine, "house" has become normal life for most people. In this case, many brick-and-mortar enterprises and stores take live streaming as their first choice for "cloud Fu" -- thousands of shoppers in Intime department store become "cloud cabinet girls", and the number of customers served by a shopping guide for three hours is equivalent to the customer flow of the previous six months. (Liu, 2017, para. 125). Faw-volkswagen organized heads of multiple departments to set up "executive live streaming group" to introduce product highlights, sales policies, and product maintenance methods to the audience in dozens of Douyin livestreamings. The merchants of Yiwu commodity market gathered in the "Cloud Open Market" to welcome consumers from all over the world in the radio room of Taobao, and launched a lively "online gathering".

Then, on April 1, Taobao anchor "Weiya" Wufen sold a rocket for 40 million yuan; Newcomer Luo Yonghao sold 110 million yuan worth of goods in three hours; Through 12 hours of livestreaminging, the team of fast anchor "Simba" finally achieved 480 million yuan of transaction volume. Therefore, the Research Report on the In-depth Analysis and Development Strategy of the Industrial Market of Internet Celebrity Economy 2020-2025 by China Industrial Research Institute predicts that the sales scale of China's e-commerce live streaming will reach 916 billion yuan in 2020, accounting for 8.7% of China's online retail scale. This represents a nearly trillion-dollar market. (Jarrett, 2014, para. 17).

Industrial platform

In news reports, various anchors create sales myths to inspire people in incredible ways. At the same time, the platform has been encouraging the presence of anchors to connect "closed" businesses with "stay-at-home" consumers in response to the profound disaster of the COVID-19 pandemic in China. Many Internet platforms, such as Taobao Live, Douyin, Kuaishang, Tencent and Suning, have extended olive branches to merchants and rolled out a series of support measures, such as fast opening, reduced service fees and operational guidance. On March 30, Alibaba partnered with Weibo, Youku and other platforms to put live streams from Taobao on part of the platform's page to provide traffic entry points. Since April, platforms such as Tencent, Pinduoduo, Xiaohongshu, B station and Douyu have added live streaming and shopping functions and called on anchors to settle in. For these anchors, "There are opportunities everywhere if you want to do it. You can see from the news that when 5G comes, the Internet speed will be faster and it will definitely develop better." (Candidate M4)

6. conclusion

When the media shouted "the 'live streaming economy' is accelerating towards us, and online China will soon become a reality", "e-commerce live streaming" entered the public's vision, gained a large number of new users and attracted a large number of new anchors.

The main group engaged in "e-commerce live streaming" is no longer the "digital labor force" in the broad sense in previous studies. They caught the communication technology as well as the personal political and economic power, seize the opportunities and meet the challenge, in such a society, the rapid progress in technology, in the face of some natural disasters, or positive or anxiously looking for a way out, the production, sharing a special, mass of entrepreneur of the grassroots culture, formed in the offline cluster, extremely has the characteristic of the host community. Specifically, they are often inspired by "Internet celebrity anchors" and the "wealth creation myth" of platforms and e-commerce villages. They divert the attention resources of traditional media and make money by performing. In pursuit of their personal "dream of wealth," they forge ahead and live their lives in work rather than performance.

In the specific practice of cultural production, these "old iron" anchors establish their self-identities (human identities) such as "businessmen" and "pusher" in livestreaming activities, look for "factories" and "shopping malls" as appropriate scenes, find selling points of commodities through early scripts, and

organize the whole livestreaming with relatively standardized procedures. During the livestreaming, he used skills such as handing out red envelopes, telling jokes and rhyming to interact with the audience, perform for the audience and liven up the atmosphere. He also uses a relatively uniform set of normative speaking techniques to persuade his audience to buy, in order to promote goods and obtain financial returns.

In general, from the perspectives of "digital labor" in the political economy of communication and "Internet celebrity economy" in media economics, this study summarizes and concretly presents the abstraction of the live performance paradigm, which fills the gap in the specific content and form of cultural production in the platform economy in the existing research. However, the shortcomings of this study are also obvious.

Firstly, as an empirical study, the universality and theoretical significance of this paper are insufficient. This study follows the purposive sampling principle, and only takes the "e-commerce live streaming" groups of "Qingyanliu" and "Xiabou" in Jiangbei of Yiwu as the research object, whose characteristics do not apply to the whole "e-commerce live streaming" main group. In contrast, the research on live-streaming platform streamtop anchors has more commercial value and theoretical significance.

Secondly, the research depth of this paper is insufficient, lack of explanation of the phenomenon. Though I try to be at the end of the article will be the host of the paradigm, life style, social background, show the host community's social identity and individual motive, engaged in electrical business live but the study failed to follow the host community and society to explore the relationship between the host platform adverse impacts on the society, economy, culture, in general, only to solve the problem of the descriptive the main unit. Subsequent research can make a deeper analysis and interpretation from the cultural production paradigm of the host community and the general platform as well as the relationship between the mutual influence on the overall development of society, evaluate the performance of the host group, and even infer and predict the reliability and validity of the platform and the development of social economy and politics on this basis.

The challenge for grassroots e-commerce live-streaming is that its user-generated content must conform to the authorities' expectations of "what kind of stories should be told". "This is particularly challenging because the stakes are high: Internet Plus is not just about 'reinventing the economy', but also

about reinventing culture and society. On the one hand, the Chinese authorities are keen to promote a curated national image to project "soft power" on the global stage, while on the other, they expect a culture of conformity to norms to ensure social stability and national unity. As Mr Sun emphasises, this refers to a dual agenda: "To present globally as a player whose values, ethics and emotions are related to... Its international rivals "while at home" avoiding 'chaos' at all costs, including harsh censorship, to ensure social stability and national unity." "This dual agenda applies to China's digital platforms. The platform culture production system places users at the center of production and gives content producers more autonomy. However, as long as these platforms operate in China, they cannot be immune to censorship or state requirements for a compliance culture. Content providers of all kinds should "abide by the law, adhere to correct values, help spread core socialist values and foster a positive and healthy online culture," according to the CAC. (Duffy & Elizabeth, 2017, para.20).

Therefore, under the policy agenda of "Internet Plus" and "mass entrepreneurship and innovation", the country's desire for economic restructuring is driving but also shaping the platformization of cultural production in China. The SOE relationship is complicated to a large extent by the dual concern of the sub-state for economic restructuring, cultural regulation and social stability. This country business relationship to live the content of the electricity production has strong chance, we believe that it will be contemporary Chinese culture platform of production and production platform of the difference between western culture and, as China is concerned, the country's power to produce the chanciness of the third dimension, and constantly plastic production practice platform of Chinese culture.

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